

JobQuest Creative Direction, UX/UI, Accessibility and Performance Plan

FINALIZED | Phase 3 developer design specification | September 19, 2026

APPROVED
DIRECTION

Use DaisyUI's Caramellatte light theme and organize every route as a clear page of functional content panels. The concept comes from comic-book page composition, but the interface does not use comic fonts, speech bubbles, halftone textures, illustrations or exaggerated comic effects.

A. Caramellatte palette

Token	DaisyUI value / sRGB preview	JobQuest use
Base 100	oklch(98.00% 0.016 73.684) #FFF7ED	Primary page canvas
Base 200	oklch(95.00% 0.038 75.164) #FEECD3	Alternate surface and hover
Base 300	oklch(90.00% 0.076 70.697) #FFD6A7	Borders and selected surfaces
Base content	oklch(40.00% 0.123 38.172) #7C2808	Main text and panel headings
Primary	oklch(0.00% 0.000 0.000) #000000	Main actions and strongest emphasis
Primary content	oklch(100.00% 0.000 0.000) #FFFFFF	Text on primary controls
Secondary	oklch(22.45% 0.075 37.850) #370A00	Secondary actions and navigation
Accent	oklch(46.44% 0.111 37.850) #8C3F27	Selected items and evidence links
Neutral	oklch(55.00% 0.195 38.402) #C93400	Neutral emphasis and metadata
Info	oklch(42.00% 0.199 265.638) #193AB7	Informational notices and extraction
Success	oklch(43.00% 0.095 166.913) #006044	Confirmed, qualified and completed
Warning	oklch(82.00% 0.189 84.429) #FCB700	Deadlines, research and caution
Error	oklch(70.00% 0.191 22.216) #FF6266	Validation, failure and destructive actions

B. Feature-to-creative-direction summary

Feature group	Creative direction
Authentication	One focused form panel; reassurance and recovery guidance remain secondary.
Candidate profile	Profile-completion overview plus modular evidence panels and calm document states.
Discovery and inbox	Dense but scannable queue panels, strong filtering and separate job/freelance contexts.
Evaluation and decisions	Score, evidence, gaps and risks occupy distinct panels; manual decision remains visually dominant.
Application preparation	Large editor panel paired with evidence and approval panels; no generated-document preview.
Tracking	Timeline-led layout with status, next action and outcome panels.

1. Creative theme and experience principles

Theme statement

JobQuest should feel focused, warm, orderly and trustworthy. Caramellatte's cream surfaces and brown content colors keep long review sessions comfortable, while black primary actions establish unmistakable priority. The panel composition makes complex workflows easier to scan without turning the application into a novelty interface.

Core experience principles

Principle	Direction	Design consequence
One route, one purpose	Every route has a clear task and completion state.	The largest panel contains the route's main task; supporting information stays beside or below it.
Panels clarify relationships	Related content shares a panel; unrelated tasks do not.	Borders, surface shifts and gutters create grouping without excessive decoration.
Human control is visible	AI, extraction and recommendations never appear final by default.	Draft, review, approval and final states use explicit labels and separate actions.
Evidence stays close	Claims, scores and tailored text show their source context.	Evidence panels remain adjacent on desktop and directly after the related content on mobile.
Status is never color-only	Every state uses text and, when helpful, a Heroicon.	Badges include readable labels; red, amber and green are supporting signals.
Motion explains change	Animation confirms transitions but never decorates idle screens.	Use short opacity, background and position transitions; support reduced motion.
Performance shapes design	The interface must remain responsive during upload, extraction and AI work.	Progress and skeleton states reserve layout space and avoid blocking unrelated panels.

Consistency rule

ROUTE CONSISTENCY

Authenticated routes share one application shell, page-header pattern, panel language, spacing scale, button hierarchy, feedback patterns and responsive stacking logic. A route may deviate only when its task benefits from a different information hierarchy; every approved deviation is documented in the route section.

Not part of the visual direction

- No gradients.
- No comic-book typography, speech bubbles, halftone patterns or illustrated effects.
- No animation that blocks input or moves content unexpectedly.
- No color-only instructions, status meanings or validation.
- No layout that forces desktop panel geometry onto a narrow screen.

2. Application shell and panel system

Authenticated shell

Region	Desktop direction	Mobile direction
Top bar	Brand, global search when available, notifications and account menu.	Compact brand, notification control and menu trigger.
Primary navigation	Persistent left rail for Dashboard, Profile, Discovery, Opportunities and Applications.	DaisyUI drawer opened from the top bar; closes after navigation.
Page header	Title, one-line purpose, status/context badges and the highest-priority action.	Title and purpose first; actions wrap beneath at full width when needed.
Content canvas	12-column CSS Grid with panel spans chosen by task priority.	Single-column flow using the same semantic source order.
Utility feedback	Toasts for short confirmations; inline alerts for recoverable work.	Same behavior, placed away from mobile navigation and keyboard.

Panel anatomy

Element	Rule
Container	DaisyUI card or semantic section; base-100 surface, 2 px theme border, 1 rem radius and subtle theme depth.
Header	Short title, optional description, status badge and at most one contextual action.
Body	Content uses internal grid/flex and a consistent spacing rhythm; avoid nested panels deeper than two levels.
Footer	Only for actions, pagination, confirmation summaries or secondary metadata.
Gutter	16 px mobile, 20 px tablet and 24 px desktop between primary panels.
Priority	Primary panel receives the largest span; secondary panels may be narrower but not visually louder.

Recommended desktop panel patterns

Pattern	Grid	Use
Focus	8 + 4 columns	Editor/detail plus evidence, status or next-action sidebar.
Overview	4 + 4 + 4 columns	Dashboard summaries and evenly weighted status panels.
Queue	9 + 3 columns	Table/list with persistent filters or import health.
Comparison	6 + 6 columns	Source versus working copy, duplicate comparison or extracted text review.
Full canvas	12 columns	Large data table, timeline or long form when a sidebar would reduce usability.

READING ORDER

DOM order follows task order, not desktop geometry. When panels stack, the main task appears first, required context follows, and destructive or archival actions remain last.

3. Typography, spacing, borders and icons

Typography

Role	Direction	Responsive behavior
Application font	Use a clean system sans-serif stack for fast rendering and familiar controls.	No font download is required for release 1.
Page title	28-32 px, bold, compact line height.	24-28 px on small screens.
Panel title	18-20 px, semibold/bold.	18 px minimum.
Body	16 px default with approximately 1.5 line height.	Never shrink to fit a panel.
Metadata	14 px minimum; use weight and labels before reducing size.	Wrap naturally rather than truncate important values.
Code/identifiers	Monospace only for technical IDs or source payloads.	Allow wrapping or horizontal scroll in code-only blocks.

Spacing and shape tokens

Token	Value	Use
xs	4 px	Icon/text separation and compact metadata.
sm	8 px	Related control spacing.
md	16 px	Mobile panel padding and form groups.
lg	24 px	Desktop panel padding and page gutters.
xl	32 px	Major section separation.
Panel radius	1 rem	Caramellatte box radius; consistent across primary panels.
Field radius	0.5 rem	Caramellatte field radius.
Selector radius	2 rem	Pills, toggles, compact filters and status badges.
Border	2 px	Caramellatte default; sufficient structure for the panel concept.

Heroicons

- Use outline icons for navigation and secondary actions; solid icons may indicate an active or completed state.
- Default size is 20 px in controls and 24 px in primary navigation.
- Icons supplement labels; unfamiliar actions never appear as icon-only controls.
- Destructive, warning and success icons inherit semantic colors and include adjacent text or an accessible name.

VISUAL RESTRAINT

Borders and spacing establish the panel composition. Shadows remain subtle and consistent; they do not imitate printed comic panels or compete with status colors.

4. Reusable controls and button system

Button hierarchy

Button	Color / shape	Purpose	Examples
Primary	Black primary fill, white text, theme field radius.	One highest-priority action per panel or page region.	Create account, Save, Run analysis, Approve final package.
Secondary	Dark-brown secondary fill with light content.	Alternative action that advances work without being primary.	Save draft, Add experience, Record response.
Outline	Transparent/cream surface with dark border and text.	Reversible, navigation or lower-priority action.	Cancel, Preview source, View history.
Ghost	No permanent fill; base-200 hover surface.	Low-emphasis utility action.	Edit note, Copy text, Open menu.
Destructive	Error color with explicit destructive label.	Delete or irreversible confirmation only.	Delete document, Permanently delete opportunity.
Warning deviation	Warning surface with dark readable text.	Time-sensitive action that is not destructive.	Review overdue item, Resolve extraction warning.

Deviation rule

BUTTON DEVIATION A feature may depart from the reusable button palette only when the standard hierarchy would communicate the wrong risk or state. The route specification must identify the different color, shape, purpose, accessible label and all hover/focus/disabled states.

Control states

Interaction	Color and visual response	Motion / feedback	Purpose
Hover	Small surface or contrast change; no layout shift.	100-150 ms color transition.	Confirms pointer target.
Keyboard focus	High-contrast 2 px outline with visible offset.	Immediate; no fade required.	Makes current keyboard position unmistakable.
Pressed	Slight darkening or 1 px visual compression.	80-120 ms; disabled for reduced motion if movement is used.	Acknowledges activation.
Loading	Label remains; spinner appears beside it; width stays fixed.	Spinner plus live status text.	Prevents duplicate actions and layout shift.
Disabled	Reduced emphasis but still legible; cursor alone is insufficient.	No animation; explain requirement nearby.	Shows unavailable action without hiding it.
Success	Brief success state or adjacent toast/inline message.	150-200 ms color fade; no celebratory motion.	Confirms completion.

5. Forms, typing, uploads and editing interactions

Form design

Element	Direction
Labels	Persistent text labels above controls; placeholders only provide examples.
Required status	Use written Required/Optional treatment; do not rely on an asterisk alone.
Help text	Place concise guidance before errors occur, especially for password, file and evidence rules.
Validation	Validate on blur for most fields and on submit for the full form; avoid error messages on the first keystroke.
Errors	Error border, icon and linked message; focus moves to an error summary after failed submission when multiple fields fail.
Long forms	Group related fields into panels or sections; preserve entered data when validation fails.
Unsaved work	Show a visible Unsaved changes state and confirm navigation when meaningful edits would be lost.

Interaction specifications

Interaction	Color and visual response	Motion / feedback	Purpose
Typing	Field border stays neutral; active field receives focus outline.	No character-by-character motion.	Maintain concentration and avoid premature errors.
Validation success	Optional success icon only when confirmation matters.	Brief opacity appearance.	Confirms valid email, file or completed requirement.
Validation error	Error border and message; typed content remains.	Immediate message; no shaking.	Explains correction without punishment.
File selection	Selected file becomes a document row/card with metadata.	Progress bar only during upload.	Makes the chosen asset and state reviewable.
Upload	Info state during transfer; success or error result per file.	Determinate progress when available; stable reserved height.	Communicates activity and partial failure.
Text extraction	Each document displays queued, extracting, review or failed state.	Spinner/progress plus live-region updates.	Keeps the fallible service transparent.
Autosave	Not assumed for release 1; use explicit Save unless implemented and disclosed.	If added, show Saving/Saved text.	Prevents ambiguous persistence.

MANUAL FALLBACK Every PDF extraction screen includes manual paste or manual entry without visually presenting it as an error-only path. Uploaded and manually entered content lead to the same review and approval state.

6. Tables, cards, filters and record selection

Desktop tables and mobile cards

Context	Desktop	Mobile
Opportunity queues	Table with persistent headers, sortable columns and row actions.	Stacked record cards containing title, organization/client, date, status, score and next action.
Profile records	Compact table or list when comparison is useful.	Editable summary cards; actions remain labelled.
Application tracking	Table for cross-record comparison; timeline inside details.	Application cards with status, due date and next action.
Import results	Result table with imported, duplicate and invalid rows.	Grouped result cards with expandable reasons.

Filtering and selection

Interaction	Color and visual response	Motion / feedback	Purpose
Open filters	Outline or ghost control; active filter count uses accent badge.	Drawer/collapse transition up to 200 ms.	Exposes controls without crowding the queue.
Apply filters	Selected pills use accent plus readable content; results announce count.	Optional 120 ms row fade; no stagger.	Shows active criteria and new result scope.
Clear filters	Ghost control beside active filter summary.	Immediate reset and result-count announcement.	Provides a reversible escape.
Sort	Header or select shows label plus direction icon.	No animation required.	Makes ordering visible to all users.
Select record	Row/card gains base-300 surface and border emphasis.	100-150 ms color transition.	Connects the queue selection to details.
Row action menu	Ghost icon button with accessible name; menu uses base-100 panel.	Short opacity/scale; focus enters menu.	Keeps secondary actions available without noise.

Density rules

- Do not compress body text below 14 px to fit more rows.
- Truncate only nonessential repeated text; provide the complete value through the detail route or accessible disclosure.
- Use pagination or incremental loading for growing queues; do not render an unbounded record list.
- No release-1 bulk actions; selection controls appear only where the approved feature requires comparison or a controlled 1-3 document extraction batch.

7. Modals, feedback, motion and status language

DaisyUI modal use

Modal	Visual direction	Required behavior
Confirmation	Focused cream panel with explicit subject and consequence.	Initial focus on heading or safe control; Escape closes unless an operation is already committing.
Destructive	Error icon/callout; destructive button is visually isolated from Cancel.	Name the exact record; require a deliberate confirmation.
Decision	Recommendation shown as context; user options remain selectable and neutral until chosen.	Do not preselect a destructive or final decision solely from AI advice.
Duplicate comparison	Wide comparison panel or full-screen mobile modal.	Preserve scroll, trap focus and clearly label Keep separate versus Merge.
Final approval	Summary of exact text, evidence/version and manual price when applicable.	Approval is explicit; closing does not approve.

Feedback hierarchy

Feedback	Use	Persistence
Inline field error	Specific correction attached to a control.	Until corrected or dismissed when appropriate.
Panel alert	Recoverable parser, extraction, AI or upload problem.	Remains with the affected work and offers Retry/manual recovery.
Toast	Short confirmation such as Saved, Copied or Archived.	3-5 seconds, pausable on hover/focus, also announced accessibly.
Status badge	Persistent state such as Needs Attention or Qualified.	Visible while the state applies; includes text.
Progress	Upload, extraction or AI analysis.	Until each operation returns success, warning or failure.

Motion baseline

- Color and opacity transitions: 100-200 ms.
- Drawer, collapse and modal transitions: no more than 250 ms.
- Avoid parallax, looping decoration, bouncing controls and animated counters.
- Do not animate large panel rearrangements after initial load.
- Under prefers-reduced-motion, remove nonessential transform and smooth-scroll behavior; state changes remain immediate and understandable.

NO SILENT WORK

Any operation longer than approximately one second presents visible progress or a clear pending state. The user may continue using unrelated panels when the underlying feature safely permits it.

8. Finalized release-1 route map

APPROVED ROUTE
BASELINE

The finalized developer plan defines the approved features and this creative plan establishes their release-1 URLs and page layouts. A later route change must preserve feature scope, navigation clarity and route-level consistency, and must be recorded through change control.

Area	Routes	Primary feature coverage
Authentication	/register; /verify-email; /login; /forgot-password; /reset-password	Features 1.1-1.8
Dashboard	/dashboard; /notifications	Cross-step summaries; Features 6.4-6.5
Candidate profile	/profile; /profile/documents; /profile/experience; /profile/projects; /profile/skills; /profile/education; /profile/preferences; /profile/versions	Features 2.1-2.7 and extraction review
Discovery	/discover/jobs; /discover/freelance; /imports; /inbound	Features 3.1-3.6
Opportunities	/opportunities/jobs; /opportunities/freelance; /opportunities/[id]	Features 4.1-4.8
Evaluation	/opportunities/[id]/evaluation	Features 5.1-5.5 and Step 6 controls
Preparation	/applications/[id]/prepare	Features 7.1-7.5
Tracking	/applications; /applications/[id]	Features 8.1-8.6
Settings	/settings/account	Account preferences and normal logout; no all-session logout

Route-level consistency checklist

- Same authenticated shell, page header and breadcrumb pattern.
- Same primary/secondary/outline/ghost/destructive control hierarchy.
- Same panel border, radius, padding and gutter system.
- Same inline validation, alert, toast, loading and empty-state patterns.
- Same focus indicators, keyboard paths and semantic heading order.
- Same mobile stacking rule: main task, required context, history, then destructive actions.
- Every deviation documents why the standard pattern would be less usable.

9. Authentication routes

Features 1.1-1.8

Route	Purpose	Panel layout	Primary interactions
/register	Create an open account.	Centered 5-6 column form panel; requirements and privacy note in a compact support panel.	Type, reveal password, submit, open login link.
/verify-email	Confirm email ownership.	Single status panel with success, expired and resend states.	Resend verification, continue to login/dashboard.
/login	Authenticate verified user.	Centered form panel; recovery link stays visible but secondary.	Type credentials, reveal password, submit, open recovery.
/forgot-password	Request reset email.	Single focused form panel with generic success result.	Type email and submit.
/reset-password	Set a new password.	Focused form plus modern-password guidance panel.	Type, reveal/confirm, submit and return to login.

Color and interaction details

Interaction	Color and visual response	Motion / feedback	Purpose
Submit authentication form	Primary black control; disabled only while valid request is pending.	Fixed-width spinner and live status.	Establishes one dominant action.
Show password	Ghost icon button inside/adjacent to field; visible focus.	No animation beyond icon swap.	Allows verification without changing the password.
Invalid credentials	Error alert without identifying whether the account exists.	Immediate after response; focus alert then form.	Balances recovery with account privacy.
Verification success	Success panel with check icon and clear next action.	Brief opacity appearance only.	Confirms state transition.
Resend link	Secondary or outline control with cooldown text if required.	Countdown only when implemented; text remains accessible.	Prevents repeated accidental requests.

LAYOUT DEVIATION Authentication routes intentionally omit the authenticated navigation shell. Their single-task, centered composition reduces distraction and prevents navigation into protected features before authentication is complete.

10. Dashboard and notification routes

Cross-step overview and Features 6.4-6.5

Route	Purpose	Panel layout	Primary interactions
/dashboard	Show current workload and next actions.	Overview grid: attention queue spans 8 columns; profile readiness and usage span 4; lower row contains discovery, applications and outcomes.	Open task, dismiss completed notice, navigate to feature.
/notifications	Review due research and saved-opportunity reminders.	Full-width list panel with filter panel above or in right rail on wide screens.	Filter, edit review date, mark complete, open opportunity.

Dashboard panel order

Priority	Panel	Color treatment	Reason
1	Needs attention / due now	Warning badges; error only for failed operations.	Time-sensitive work must be seen first.
2	Profile readiness	Neutral base with success when requirements are complete.	Preparation eligibility affects later workflow.
3	Discovery and inbox counts	Base panels with accent links.	Supports daily review without implying urgency.
4	Applications and outcomes	Status badges use semantic colors plus text.	Shows progress and follow-up workload.
5	Resend usage	Neutral until 80%; warning at threshold.	Cost awareness should not dominate normal use.

Interactions

Interaction	Color and visual response	Motion / feedback	Purpose
Open task	Selected panel/row receives base-300 emphasis.	Short color transition.	Connects summary to detailed work.
Edit due date	Outline edit control opens labelled modal or inline date field.	Modal/collapse up to 200 ms.	Keeps the user in control of reminders.
Complete reminder	Success confirmation and item moves to completed section.	Short fade; no immediate disappearance before confirmation.	Confirms completion while preserving history.

11. Candidate profile overview and documents

Features 2.1, 2.7 and X.1-X.4

Route	Purpose	Panel layout	Primary interactions
/profile	Summarize profile readiness and evidence.	Readiness panel spans full width; modular panels for documents, experience, projects, skills, education and preferences.	Open section, resolve missing requirement, review current version.
/profile/documents	Manage required master files and extracted text.	Document list above; upload/extraction panel plus side-by-side file/text review when active.	Upload, replace, extract, retry, edit text, approve text.

Document state design

State	Color and layout	Action
Missing	Neutral dashed/outlined document panel with Required label.	Upload or enter content.
Uploading	Info progress bar with filename and cancel only when safe.	Wait or cancel.
Uploaded	Base panel with file metadata and neutral status.	Extract, replace or delete.
Extracting	Info badge/progress; other document panels remain usable.	Wait; no duplicate request.
Needs review	Warning badge; raw/corrected text comparison is prominent.	Edit and approve or use manual entry.
Approved	Success badge with approver/time and version context.	View, replace or create new attempt.
Failed	Error alert inside the affected document panel.	Retry, replace file or enter text manually.

LAYOUT DEVIATION	The document route uses a comparison layout rather than a standard form because the user must evaluate an original PDF and fallible extracted text together. On mobile, file metadata comes first, followed immediately by editable extracted text and approval controls.
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12. Candidate profile record routes

Features 2.2-2.7

Route	Purpose	Panel layout	Primary interactions
/profile/experience	Maintain truthful employment evidence.	Record list plus editor panel; evidence links appear in the selected record.	Create, edit, confirm, archive, restore.
/profile/projects	Maintain portfolio, freelance and personal work.	Project cards/list plus detail editor; label project type visibly.	Create, edit, link evidence, archive.
/profile/skills	Maintain skills and proof.	Searchable skill list with evidence/count panel and editor modal/panel.	Add, edit, confirm, link evidence.
/profile/education	Maintain education and credentials.	Compact record list and edit panel.	Create, edit, confirm, archive.
/profile/preferences	Set opportunity preferences.	Grouped form panels for work type, location, compensation and availability.	Type/select, save, reset section.
/profile/versions	Inspect immutable confirmed snapshots.	Version list in left panel; selected snapshot and change summary in main panel.	Select version, compare, return to current.

Shared interaction details

Interaction	Color and visual response	Motion / feedback	Purpose
Create record	Primary or secondary control depending on whether the section is empty.	Editor appears without moving unrelated content unexpectedly.	Adds structured evidence.
Confirm fact	Success-oriented result after explicit save; Draft label remains until confirmation.	Brief badge transition.	Separates usable evidence from unfinished data.
Archive	Outline/ghost action followed by confirmation; not red by default because reversible.	Toast plus archived-state badge.	Removes clutter while retaining history.
Delete	Error control only inside destructive confirmation.	No decorative animation.	Communicates irreversible removal.
Link evidence	Accent link/control and selected evidence chips.	Chip addition/removal uses short fade.	Makes support for a claim visible.

13. Discovery and import routes

Features 3.1-3.6

Route	Purpose	Panel layout	Primary interactions
/discover/jobs	Bulk-paste weekday job discoveries.	Large paste panel spans 8 columns; import rules and recent batch summary use 4-column side panels.	Paste, preview, correct, import.
/discover/freelance	Quick-capture freelance opportunities.	Focused capture form plus recent entries and duplicate guidance panels.	Type/paste, validate, save another.
/imports	Review import batches and row outcomes.	Batch summary panels above full-width result table/cards.	Filter, expand invalid row, open created record.
/inbound	Review Resend alert intake and parser failures.	Activity queue spans 9 columns; usage and parser-health panels span 3.	Filter, inspect, retry supported parsing, open Needs Attention.

Color and interaction details

Interaction	Color and visual response	Motion / feedback	Purpose
Paste content	Neutral textarea; preview control stays secondary until content exists.	No parsing animation while typing.	Avoids processing uncommitted text.
Preview	Info summary separates valid, duplicate, too-old and invalid results.	Progress only while parsing; announce counts.	Prevents surprising imports.
Import	Primary control after preview; result uses per-category status colors and labels.	Fixed control width; no duplicate submit.	Commits reviewed candidates.
Quota threshold	Neutral below 80%; warning at 80%; error only when service cannot accept more.	No pulsing or alarm motion.	Communicates cost/availability accurately.
Parser failure	Warning or error panel with original content preserved.	Appears inline with recovery action.	Ensures no silent data loss.

LAYOUT DEVIATION Jobs use a wide batch workspace because multiple records are reviewed together. Freelance Quick Capture remains a smaller focused form because release 1 prioritizes fast single-record entry.

14. Opportunity inbox routes

Features 4.1-4.8

Route	Purpose	Panel layout	Primary interactions
/opportunities/jobs	Review employment opportunities separately.	Queue table/cards spans 9 columns; filters and status counts use a 3-column rail.	Search, filter, sort, open, archive.
/opportunities/freelance	Review freelance projects separately.	Same queue pattern with freelance-specific columns for budget, scope and deadline.	Search, filter, sort, open, archive.

Queue visual rules

Element	Jobs	Freelance	Shared rule
Primary label	Role title and employer.	Project title and client/platform.	Title is a real link with visible focus.
Age	Business-day recency and posting date.	Posting date/deadline when known.	Warning only when action is time-sensitive.
Compensation	Salary/hourly/unknown.	Budget/fixed/hourly/unknown.	Unknown stays explicit; no blank ambiguity.
Status	New, Needs Attention, In Review, Ready for Evaluation, Saved, Archived.	Same status vocabulary.	Badge includes text and semantic icon when useful.
Row action	Open is primary row action; archive is secondary.	Same.	No bulk actions in release 1.

Empty and loading states

- Empty inbox: explain how opportunities enter this inbox and provide the correct capture/import action.
- No filter results: summarize active filters and provide Clear filters; do not show a generic empty inbox.
- Loading: render a stable table/card skeleton matching expected row heights.
- Failed load: keep filter state and provide Retry; do not replace the entire shell with an error page.

CONSISTENCY

Job and freelance inboxes use the same panel framework, control positions and responsive behavior. Only fields and labels that reflect their different opportunity types change.

15. Opportunity detail and extraction experience

Features 4.1-4.8 and X.1-X.4

Route	Purpose	Panel layout	Primary interactions
/opportunities/[id]	Review source, working fields, attachments, notes and history.	Header/status across full width; working detail spans 8 columns; source/next-action rail spans 4; notes and history follow below.	Edit, save, attach, extract, compare duplicate, archive/delete.

Panel sequence

Order	Panel	Purpose
1	Opportunity header	Title, organization/client, type, status, dates and primary next action.
2	Working copy	Editable normalized fields used by evaluation and tracking.
3	Original source	Immutable email, pasted content, uploaded posting or source metadata.
4	Attachments and extracted text	Optional upload, extraction status, editable review and approval.
5	Notes and tags	User context that does not alter source evidence.
6	Activity history	Imports, edits, merges, decisions, archives, restores and deletion events.
7	Danger zone	Permanent deletion after explicit confirmation.

Source versus working copy

Interaction	Color and visual response	Motion / feedback	Purpose
Edit working field	Focused field and Unsaved changes status.	No source content movement.	Corrects normalized data without rewriting evidence.
View original	Outline disclosure/control; source panel uses distinct base-200 surface.	Collapse up to 200 ms.	Makes immutability understandable.
Approve extracted text	Primary action only after review; success badge records time.	Brief state change; raw result remains available.	Separates extraction from trusted application data.
Merge duplicate	Comparison modal with neutral choices and warning summary.	Focus-trapped modal.	Preserves all sources before combining records.

LAYOUT DEVIATION

The immutable source panel uses a visually different surface and read-only treatment so it cannot be mistaken for the editable working copy. The difference serves source integrity, not decoration.

16. Evaluation route

Features 5.1-5.5

Route	Purpose	Panel layout	Primary interactions
/opportunities/[id]/evaluation	Create and review an explainable qualification result.	Opportunity/evidence context above; score panel spans 4 columns; evidence, strengths, gaps and risks span 8; recommendation and manual decision remain separate.	Run analysis, open evidence, compare version, choose decision.

Evaluation color rules

Element	Direction	Reason
Overall score	Large numeric score plus Qualified/Below threshold text; success may support 75+, neutral/warning supports lower results.	The score remains readable without interpreting color.
Category score	Consistent bars or rows with numbers and labels; avoid red-green-only comparison.	Users need exact values and categories.
Strength	Success icon/border used lightly.	Shows supported evidence, not a guarantee.
Gap	Warning treatment unless the underlying input failed.	A gap is research or missing evidence, not a system error.
Risk	Warning or error depending on severity, always with text.	Separates concern from confirmed failure.
Recommendation	Neutral/accent advisory panel; never visually stronger than manual decision controls.	AI is advisory and cannot decide for the user.

Interactions

Interaction	Color and visual response	Motion / feedback	Purpose
Run analysis	Primary black action; shows exact profile version/context.	Progress panel with live status; no fake percentage.	Makes AI execution intentional.
Open evidence	Accent link reveals evidence panel or anchored detail.	Short scroll/focus transition; reduced-motion safe.	Supports explainability.
Re-evaluate	Secondary action with version warning.	Creates new result; old panel does not disappear.	Preserves immutable evaluation history.
Choose next decision	Decision controls remain neutral until selected.	Selected state uses base-300/accent border.	Prevents AI recommendation from appearing automatic.

17. Decision and reminder experience

Features 6.1-6.5

Decision controls live on the evaluation route

A separate decision URL is unnecessary for release 1. The decision panel follows the evaluation output so users can compare evidence, risks and recommendation before committing a next action.

Decision	Color treatment	Interaction and purpose
Prepare Application	Primary black after selection/confirmation.	Advances to preparation; most prominent positive next step.
Needs Research	Warning/accent treatment with 14-day reminder summary.	Opens research questions and editable reminder date.
Save for Later	Secondary/outline treatment with deadline summary.	Shows posting deadline or 14-day fallback before save.
Skip	Neutral outline before selection; warning confirmation if needed.	Requires standardized reason; Other requires a comment.
Archive	Ghost/outline treatment because reversible.	Moves from active view but retains history.

Interaction details

Interaction	Color and visual response	Motion / feedback	Purpose
Select decision	Selected card/control gains accent border and base-300 surface.	100-150 ms color transition.	Makes the pending choice visible before commit.
Override recommendation	Info callout preserves recommendation and shows selected choice.	No alarm animation.	Communicates intentional human control.
Choose skip reason	DaisyUI modal with radio/list controls and comment field.	Focus trap; validation remains inline.	Records consistent analysis while allowing context.
Set reminder date	Date control plus plain-language date summary.	Immediate summary update.	Reduces date ambiguity.
Past deadline	Warning alert, not an automatic status change.	No pulsing.	Warns without overruling the user.

ACCESSIBILITY	Decision cards must use real radio/button semantics rather than clickable generic containers. Recommendation, current decision and previous decisions each receive distinct text labels.
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18. Application preparation route

Features 7.1-7.5

Route	Purpose	Panel layout	Primary interactions
/applications/[id]/prepare	Build copy-ready employment or freelance content from approved evidence.	Editor spans 8 columns; evidence, source version and approval checklist span 4; final approval summary becomes full-width when opened.	Select evidence, request draft, type/edit, copy, enter price, approve.

Employment mode

Panel	Direction
Section navigator	Headings mirror the master resume/cover-letter structure; selected section is visibly active.
Tailored text editor	Large labelled text areas by section; copy control sits beside each completed section.
Evidence	Shows selected skills, experience and projects with truthful source labels.
Gaps/questions	Warning panel remains separate from tailored content so uncertainty is not copied accidentally.

Freelance mode

Panel	Direction
Proposal editor	Copy-ready proposal, assumptions, questions, deliverables and time estimate.
Pricing	Manual hourly/fixed-price inputs, estimated hours, total, deposit and milestones when used.
Evidence	Relevant portfolio/project proof and confirmed experience.
Approval	Exact text and price summary; no send action exists.

Interaction details

Interaction	Color and visual response	Motion / feedback	Purpose
Generate draft	Primary only when no draft exists; later generations use secondary treatment.	Indeterminate progress with stage text.	Keeps AI assistance intentional and versioned.
Edit text	Neutral editor with Unsaved changes badge.	No animated typing helpers.	Supports full human control.
Copy section	Ghost/outline action; toast confirms copied heading.	Brief toast; no layout shift.	Supports manual formatting outside JobQuest.
Approve	Primary black control inside final summary modal/panel.	Success result records version and time.	Freezes reviewed text and manual price.

19. Application tracking routes

Features 8.1-8.6

Route	Purpose	Panel layout	Primary interactions
/applications	Compare active and completed applications.	Full-width table/cards with status filters; due and outcome summaries above.	Filter, sort, open, record submission.
/applications/[id]	Track one submission, responses, events and outcome.	Status/next action spans 4 columns; timeline spans 8; approved snapshot, notes and outcome panels follow.	Record response, follow-up, interview, assessment or outcome.

Timeline direction

Element	Visual treatment
Event	Chronological marker, event type label, date/time, notes and actor/source.
Current status	Clearly identified above the timeline; not inferred from the last marker alone.
Follow-up due	Warning badge when approaching/due; plain-language date and editable control.
Completed/closed	Success for accepted/won; neutral/error as appropriate for declined, rejected, lost or withdrawn, always with text.
Approved snapshot	Read-only panel showing the exact prepared content associated with submission.

Interactions

Interaction	Color and visual response	Motion / feedback	Purpose
Record submission	Primary action while Prepared; becomes status display afterward.	Confirmation modal/panel and success result.	Creates immutable submission snapshot.
Add response/event	Secondary action opens event form.	Modal or inline panel up to 200 ms.	Preserves manual communication history.
Change status	Select/control previews transition before save.	Immediate validation; history entry on commit.	Avoids accidental closure.
Record outcome	Outcome confirmation states consequences and required details.	No celebration or failure animation.	Closes the workflow accurately.

LAYOUT DEVIATION

The detail route is timeline-led because sequence and history are its primary meaning. Other routes use task/editor-led layouts; this route prioritizes chronology while keeping current status and next action visible.

20. Account settings route

Authentication support

Route	Purpose	Panel layout	Primary interactions
/settings/account	Manage account information and normal logout.	Account details and password panels span 8 columns; session and support information use 4; logout remains a standard account action.	Edit account, change password, logout.

Design rules

- Normal logout is visible in the account menu and settings route; it deletes the current secure cookie session.
- Do not display Log out all sessions because Redis/session revocation is not in the finalized technology baseline.
- Changing or resetting a password must not claim that other browser sessions were invalidated.
- Account deletion is not introduced unless added to the approved workflow and developer plans.
- Security messages use direct language and do not expose whether another person's email address is registered.

Interactions

Interaction	Color and visual response	Motion / feedback	Purpose
Save account	Primary action within account panel.	Loading state and success alert.	Confirms persisted changes.
Change password	Secondary action opens dedicated form panel/modal.	Focus moves to heading/first field.	Keeps sensitive task separated.
Logout	Neutral/outline action, not destructive red.	Immediate pending state then redirect.	Ends only the current session.

SCOPE

This route contains only controls supported by the finalized developer plan. Future session revocation, account deletion or advanced security settings require approved requirements and technology amendments.

21. Accessibility baseline

Target: WCAG 2.2 Level AA

Area	Requirement
Semantics	Use native headings, landmarks, links, buttons, inputs, tables and lists before adding ARIA.
Keyboard	Every task is operable without a pointer; focus order follows the visual/DOM task sequence.
Focus	Visible high-contrast focus indicator is never removed; modal focus is trapped and restored to its trigger.
Contrast	Normal text meets at least 4.5:1 and large text at least 3:1; non-text UI boundaries and focus indicators meet applicable 3:1 requirements.
Color	Status, score, validation and selection never rely on color alone.
Forms	Every field has a persistent label, programmatic description and linked error when invalid.
Targets	Aim for at least 44 by 44 CSS px for primary touch controls; never fall below WCAG 2.2's 24 by 24 CSS px minimum target rule unless an allowed exception applies.
Motion	Respect prefers-reduced-motion and avoid flashing, parallax and unexpected animated rearrangement.
Status messages	Save, upload, extraction, AI and validation results are exposed through appropriate live-region/status semantics without moving focus unnecessarily.
Tables	Use caption/accessible name and header associations; mobile card alternatives preserve labels and meaning.
Modals	Label the dialog, describe the consequence, trap focus, support Escape when safe and restore focus.
Timing	Do not impose short interaction timeouts; explain expiration for verification/reset tokens and allow recovery.

Testing expectations

- Keyboard-only walkthrough of every critical route and modal.
- Automated accessibility checks as support, followed by manual semantic and screen-reader review.
- Contrast validation for DaisyUI token combinations actually used, including hover, disabled, warning and error states.
- Zoom and reflow review at 200% and narrow viewport widths without loss of content or function.
- Reduced-motion review and visible-focus review for every interactive component.
- Error-identification review with intentionally invalid forms and failed service states.

SOURCE

Accessibility requirements follow W3C Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.2 Level AA. The implemented color combinations must be tested; belonging to a named DaisyUI theme does not itself prove contrast compliance.

22. Responsiveness and performance alignment

Responsive behavior

Range	Layout behavior
Small / mobile	Single-column panel flow; drawer navigation; full-width primary actions when helpful; tables become labelled cards or purposeful horizontal regions only when comparison demands it.
Medium / tablet	Two-column layouts where content remains readable; filter panels may collapse or move above results.
Large / desktop	12-column canvas with Focus, Overview, Queue, Comparison or Full-canvas patterns.
Very wide	Content max-width prevents scanning lines from becoming excessive; panels do not spread merely to fill the screen.

Performance rules that affect creative direction

Concern	Design requirement	Implementation effect
Initial load	Render useful shell and route heading immediately.	Prefer server-rendered/static structure; hydrate only interactive regions.
Layout shift	Reserve size for progress, alerts, icons and expected data rows.	Skeletons match final geometry; avoid late font/image changes.
Long queues	Preserve scanning and input responsiveness.	Paginate or incrementally load; avoid rendering unbounded records.
AI/extraction	Show honest pending states without freezing the route.	Operation status is localized per panel and supports retry/manual fallback.
Images/files	Do not render full PDFs or large previews automatically.	Use metadata/explicit preview; load only when requested.
Animation	Motion communicates change only.	Use transform/opacity sparingly; avoid animation libraries unless approved.
Icons	Consistent vector icons without image requests.	Import only required Heroicons to support tree-shaking.
Fonts	Fast, predictable text rendering.	Use system font stack in release 1; no blocking web-font dependency.

Conflict rule

NO DESIGN/PERFORMANCE CONFLICT

A creative choice is not approved if it causes excessive JavaScript, blocks meaningful content, shifts the page after interaction, prevents keyboard/screen-reader use or weakens responsiveness. Preserve the panel hierarchy with CSS Grid/Flex and semantic HTML before considering extra client-side behavior.

23. Cross-route state and consistency rules

State	Required content	Visual treatment	Recovery/action
Loading	What is loading and whether the user can continue elsewhere.	Skeleton/progress on the affected panel only.	Wait; cancel only when safe.
Empty	Why no records exist and how to create/import one.	Calm base panel with one relevant action.	Start the correct workflow.
No results	Active filters/search and result count.	Neutral message inside queue panel.	Clear or adjust filters.
Success	What changed and relevant version/status.	Success alert/badge plus text.	Continue, view or undo when supported.
Warning	Risk, missing information or approaching deadline.	Warning alert/badge plus plain language.	Review, research, edit or continue deliberately.
Error	What failed, what was preserved and stable recovery steps.	Error alert localized to affected work.	Retry, replace, correct or use manual fallback.
Offline/network	Unsaved state and whether server action completed.	Persistent error/status panel.	Retry without duplicating committed work.
Unauthorized	Generic access message without exposing another user's record.	Simple error route/panel.	Return to safe owned route or login.

When a route may look different

Deviation	Approved purpose
Authentication centered layout	Removes protected navigation and keeps a single identity task focused.
Document/extraction comparison	Places original file context beside editable fallible output.
Discovery batch workspace	Supports reviewing multiple parsed candidates before committing an import.
Opportunity source surface	Distinguishes immutable evidence from the editable working copy.
Evaluation score layout	Makes score, evidence, gaps, risks and recommendation simultaneously reviewable.
Application editor	Prioritizes long-form copy-ready content and adjacent evidence.
Tracking timeline	Prioritizes chronology and current status over form editing.

CONSISTENCY TEST A different grid is acceptable; a different design language is not. Deviating routes retain the same theme tokens, panel anatomy, typography, buttons, feedback, accessibility and responsive source-order rules.

24. Final approval and change-control record

Approved creative-direction decisions

- DaisyUI Caramellatte is the release-1 theme foundation.
- Routes use a functional comic-page panel composition without comic-book decoration.
- UX/UI, accessibility, responsiveness and performance are part of the same creative specification.
- Every feature and user interaction receives color, feedback, motion and purpose guidance.
- Reusable buttons remain consistent; deviations must state color, shape, purpose and all interaction states.
- Every route receives a layout specification, and purposeful layout differences are explained.
- The finalized Developer Feature and Technology Plan controls feature scope.

Finalized implementation baseline

Implementation item	Finalized direction	Change-control impact
Route names	Use the release-1 route map in Section 8.	A URL or navigation-label revision must update the affected route specification and tests.
Typography	Use a system sans-serif stack for release 1.	A web font requires performance, licensing and accessibility review.
Desktop navigation	Use a persistent left rail with a compact top bar.	A different shell requires review across every authenticated route and breakpoint.
Panel structure	Keep Caramellatte's 2 px border and 1 rem box radius.	A change affects the core visual identity and shared component specification.
Dark theme	Not included in release 1; Caramellatte is the approved light theme.	Dark mode requires a second tested palette and complete interaction-state matrix.
Animations	Use only the short native transitions defined in this plan.	Any animation library requires developer-plan dependency approval.

Change-control rule

FINALIZED BASELINE

This document is the approved Phase 3 implementation baseline. A later visual change that affects routes, reusable components, accessibility, responsiveness, performance, dependencies or user interaction behavior must update the relevant specification before implementation. Small content corrections may be recorded without reopening unrelated approved sections.

References

- DaisyUI built-in Caramellatte theme tokens, version 5.7.42: <https://daisyui.com/docs/themes/>
- W3C Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.2: <https://www.w3.org/TR/WCAG22/>
- W3C Understanding WCAG 2.2: <https://www.w3.org/WAI/WCAG22/Understanding/>